
NEWS

Anti-Flock Organizers Ramp Up Bay Area Protests, Urging Cities to Cut Ties With Company

Activists are holding events across the region through next week, urging cities to shut off license plate readers.

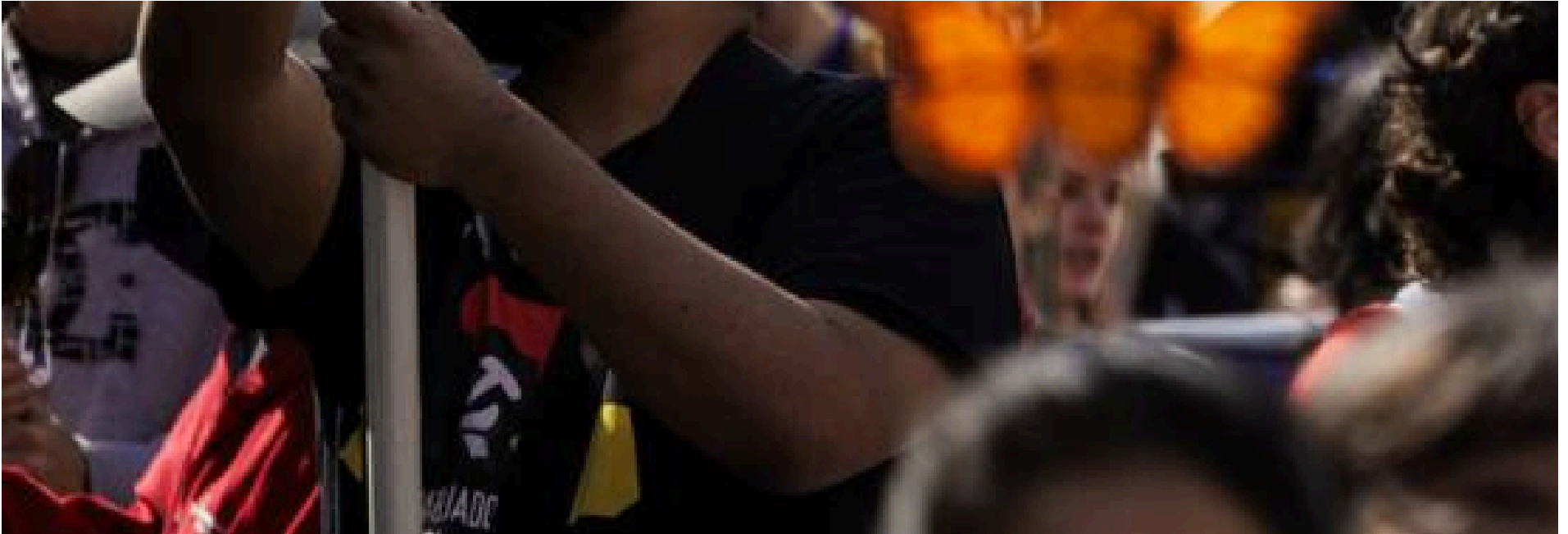
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By Ayah Ali-Ahmad









Protesters march carrying a papier-mache camera to protest the use of Flock security cameras at the Oakland Sin Fronteras May Day march in Oakland on May 1, 2026. *(Martin do Nascimento/KQED)*

[Bay Area](#) activists launched a multi-day wave of protests this week to demand that cities shut off automated license plate readers entirely instead of adopting new regulations.

The mobilization by 20 immigrant rights groups, climate organizers and other community groups is part of a national week of action and arrives as the technology and its primary provider, Fl

These moves followed [audits](#) and public records that showed federal and out-of-state agencies accessed local camera data in apparent violation of a 2015 California law that bars it. Flock anno

Organizers say the changes don't go far enough.







Organizers speak during a rally opposing Berkeley's proposed contract expansion with surveillance company Flock Safety outside the Berkeley Unified School District boardroom in Berkeley on May 7, 2026. *(Gustavo Hernandez/KQED)*

“We cannot sacrifice every person’s rights for the false and dangerous illusion of safety,” said Kimberly Woo, a community organizer with the Services, Immigrant Rights and Education Network. Many of the events are taking place in Bay Area cities that are actively grappling with how to best balance public safety with privacy. In Palo Alto, where organizers gathered Thursday evening to discuss Flock data, something city police said they had not authorized.

Other Bay Area cities have embraced the technology. The Oakland City Council [voted in December](#) to renew and expand its Flock network in a \$2.25 million, two-year deal, adding pan-tilt-zoom







San José Mayor Matt Mahan helps install a Flock Safety automated license plate reader on April 23, 2024. Civil liberties groups are now suing the city and Mahan over the technology's uses. *(Joseph Geha/KQED)*

Police departments have consistently defended the cameras as among their most effective investigative tools. San José Police Chief Paul Joseph told the [city council in March](#) that no technology. Anti-Flock advocates reject the link between the cameras and safety. Woo said crime has been trending down nationally for years for reasons that predate the cameras, and that clearance rates. In an email [earlier this month](#), Flock spokesperson Courtney Terlecki told KQED that pulling out a technology that is actively helping solve violent crimes moves public safety backward, leaving

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She added it supported more than a million criminal investigations in 2025 and helped locate more than 10,000 missing people, and that new city partnerships this year have outpaced nonre

In Gilroy on Sunday, organizers plan to draw a connection between Flock cameras, a planned Amazon data center and an ICE processing facility under construction to highlight the dangers of

A lot of the group's concerns center around the use of license plate readers for immigration enforcement. Woo described immigrants who fear that a trip to work, school or the grocery store co

In an email to KQED, the youth climate group Sunrise Movement's Bay Area chapter said that it sees the two fights as connected. Getting to a "green economy," one that runs on clean energy :

"We want cities and counties to completely reject ALPRs and mass surveillance and instead invest in initiatives that create healthy communities like education, affordable housing, green jobs,

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